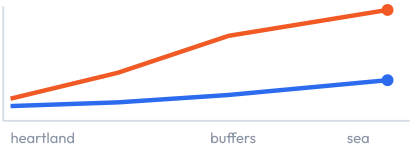
INFOGRAPHIC · TIM MARSHALL, PRISONERS OF GEOGRAPHY

China's development and why Africa's path is different

Similarities



Both are large-scale regions, whose development was determined by their natural geography: natural barriers decided where people could settle, trade and be governed. Both have had to live with buffers, whilst aiding China, Africa as a continent is greatly...

Population growth



One in four people will be African

Which would be bigger?



Africa is roughly three times China's land area, acting as a continent, which struggles with religious divide and vested interest from many countries, rendering it extremely difficult to develop even infrastructure, exacerbated by the difficulties of terrain for example, th...

Naval exploits + sea navigation



A green-water navy patrols China's maritime borders, now the world's largest navy. Through the Nine-Dash Line China claims almost the whole of the South China Sea, displaying naval dominance over a local area. This allows China to divide countries,...

01 Agriculture + geographical features



China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, an imaginary line from Heihe to the province of Yunan, explains the disparity of China's population and...

02 Borders + buffer zones



China's large geographical expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones in the border regions to protect it from instability and possible threats. The buffers act as a deterrent to invaders, which make...

03 Naval exploits + sea navigation



A green-water navy patrols China's maritime borders, now the world's largest navy. Through the Nine-Dash Line China claims almost the whole of the South China Sea, displaying naval dominance over a local area. This...

01 Natural barriers



Africa's geography is a negative factor. Its great rivers are broken by waterfalls and rapids, so they are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. It has little connectiveness to European and even Asian...

02 Borders drawn by colonialism + war



The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups, for example in Sudan and Somalia. This promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and therefore political, social and...

03 Population growth



Perhaps Africa's biggest challenge is population growth: within decades one in four people on Earth will be African. The continent as a whole, to accommodate this massive increase in numbers will need to not only...

Similarities

Both are large-scale regions, whose development was determined by their natural geography: natural barriers...

Differences

China has one fertile, river-linked heartland walled in by mountains and desert, so it became a single centralise...

Which would be bigger?

Africa is roughly three times China's land area, acting as a continent, which struggles with religious divide and vest...

Why does one develop faster?

China's geography concentrates people, food and power, letting the state plan, build and now project force at sea....